Beethoven's Piano Sonata No. 15 in D major Op. 28 and Sonata No. 25 in G major, Op. 79 were composed in 1801 and 1809 respectively. The structure and general disposition of both sonatas, however, leave the listener with echoes or foreshadowing of another time in the composer's musical development. One's first instinct upon listening to the earlier sonata, Op. 28, with its irregular phrase patterns and complex development, is that it is more representative of Beethoven's later period. Adversely, though it was composed eight years later, at first glance, Op. 79 seems to suggest trace remnants of Haydn's influence with its seemingly classicist structure and balanced, lively tone. Upon closer study, however, we discover the latter piece to be remarkably sophisticated and avant-garde.

Both sonatas also have a definitive, if rare, folk influence. Op. 79 was based on folk song and dance forms, whereas, although Beethoven did not give the Op. 28 the nickname "Pastorale" himself, it clearly has pastoral quality and influences; particularly the final movement *Allegro ma non troppo* in which he uses a Scottish bagpipe drone motive as the point of departure for the main theme of his rondo. Beethoven's characteristic intuition to stretch himself and always encourage the music to proceed with momentum even in seemingly simple pieces is uniquely evident throughout Op. 79.

The following study will explore, contrast, and compare Op. 79 and the *Allegro ma non troppo* rondo of Op. 28 in terms of compositional techniques, self-borrowings that would be instrumental in Beethoven's own musical development, the application of folk influences to the form, structure, and character of these pieces, and the avant-garde devices of Op. 28 and Op.79; two of Beethoven's less discussed sonatas.

Beethoven's Piano Sonata in D major Op. 28 was one of several works (along with Op. 27, Nos. 1 and 2; Op. 29; Op. 33; Op. 24; and Op. 26) marking the onset of his middle-period style.[1] Much has been written about the nickname "Pastoral" which was given to the sonata by Beethoven's publisher A. Cranz. Martha Frohlich writes: "While the nickname "Pastoral" did not originate with Beethoven, it may have been generated by his prominent use of lilting melodies with drone-like, pedal-point accompaniments for the primary themes in the outer movements, as well as by the folk-like style of the Scherzo."[2] Andras Schiff refers to the opening bagpipe-like drone (see Figure 1) in the main theme of the Op. 28 Rondo as "proof this is a pastoral sonata" and mentions the similarity of the swinging 6/8 meter of the final movement with the 6/8 of the pastoral symphony. Taub points out, however, that "the autograph of Op. 28 bears Beethoven's own inscription, 'Gran Sonate.'"[3]

Tovey disagrees with the previously scholars in his opinion of what Beethoven regarded as pastoral: "The publisher, Cranz of Hamburg, gave this sonata the not inappropriate title *Pastorale.* Beethoven would not have so named it; his notions of "pastoral" style, as shown in his Pastoral Symphony, are much more definitely "racy of the soil" than anything that can be found in this rich and subtle composition, which approaches the *volkstümlich* or bucolic style only in the cadence-theme of the first movement and the main theme of the Rondo."[4]
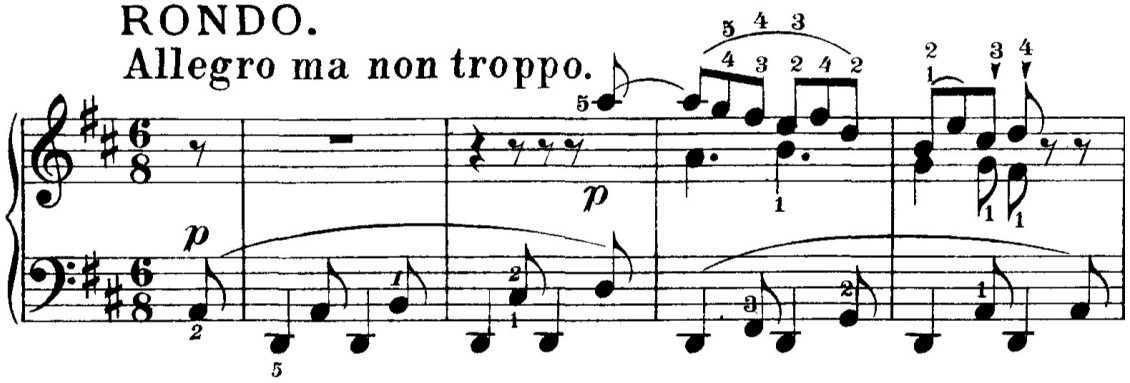
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[1] Frohlich, Martha. 1998. "Ideas of Closure, Derivation and Rhythm in the Sketches for the Andante of Beethoven's "Pastorale" Sonata Op. 28". *The Journal of Musicology.* 16, no. 3: 344.

[2] Ibid.

[3] Taub, Robert. *Playing the Beethoven Piano Sonatas*. (Portland, Or: Amadeus Press, 2002): 234.

[4] Tovey, Donald Francis. A Companion to Beethoven's Pianoforte Sonatas: (Bar to Bar Analysis). (London: Associated Board of the Royal Schools of Music, 1931): 121.

Figure 1: Beethoven, Piano Sonata No. 15 Op. 28/IV: *Allegro ma non troppo,* mm. 1-5



Taub compares the first and final movements: "The repeated Ds at the opening of this sonata immediately establish feelings of calm and stability—integral to this work—which are continued by the many different contexts and incarnations of repeated notes in each movement… [In the *Allegro ma non troppo*] the pulse is six eighth-notes to a measure, and as in the first movement, the low D serves as anchor point throughout the first theme."[5]

In reference to the tempo of the lilting 6/8 of Op. 28's final movement, this is the first use of the *ma non troppo* suffix by Beethoven in any work. It is clear that he wanted the bagpipe drone to allow the right hand melody to lilt in a way that, like most of Beethoven's compositional devices, would stimulate forward momentum.

Rosen compares this movement to another famous rondo: "This is very rustic. After a long harp-like passage of arpeggios *molto legato,* (Figure 2) a new motif descends imitatively from soprano to bass, (Figure 3) and is followed by a second pastoral drone, which acts as a

[5] Taub: 235.

concluding theme. Following the tradition of the Mozart rondo, Beethoven adds a new theme in the subdominant after the return of the opening theme. Some elaborate and expressive three-part imitative counterpoint comes next, (Figure 4) based, I believe, on the development of the Mozart rondo in the great Sonata in F major for four hands, one piano (K. 497). An inversion of the concluding drone theme from the exposition ends the development with a pedal point on the dominant."[6]

Figure 2: Beethoven, Piano Sonata No. 15 Op. 28/IV: *Allegro ma non troppo,* mm.
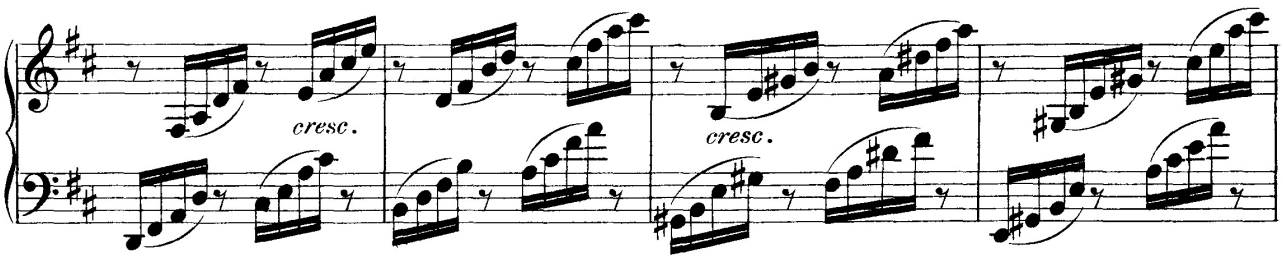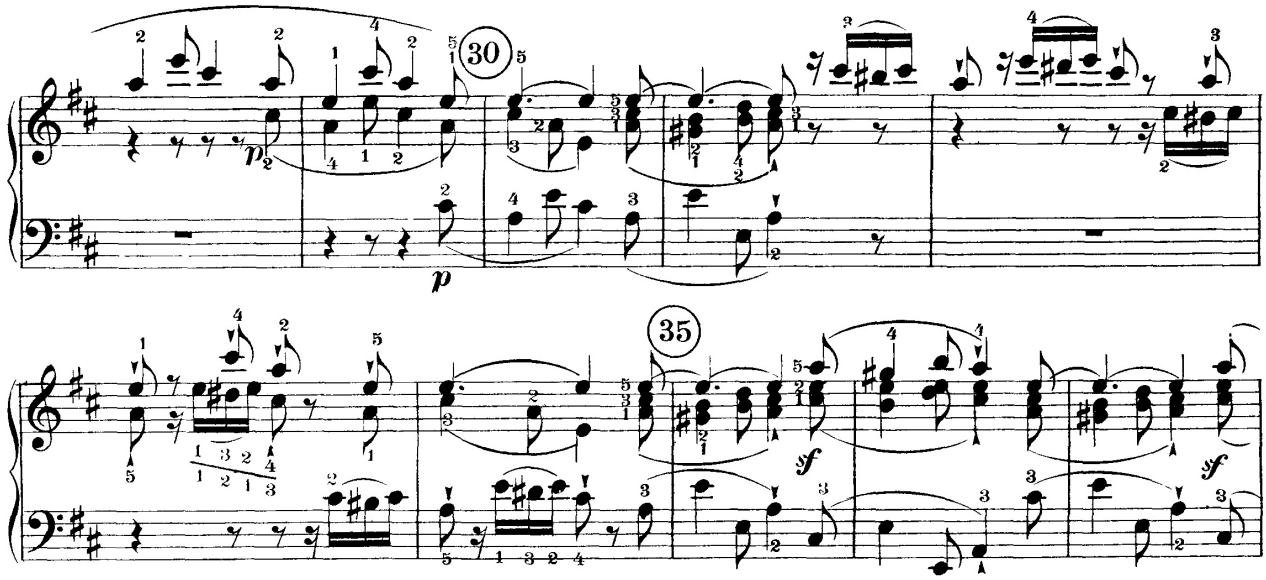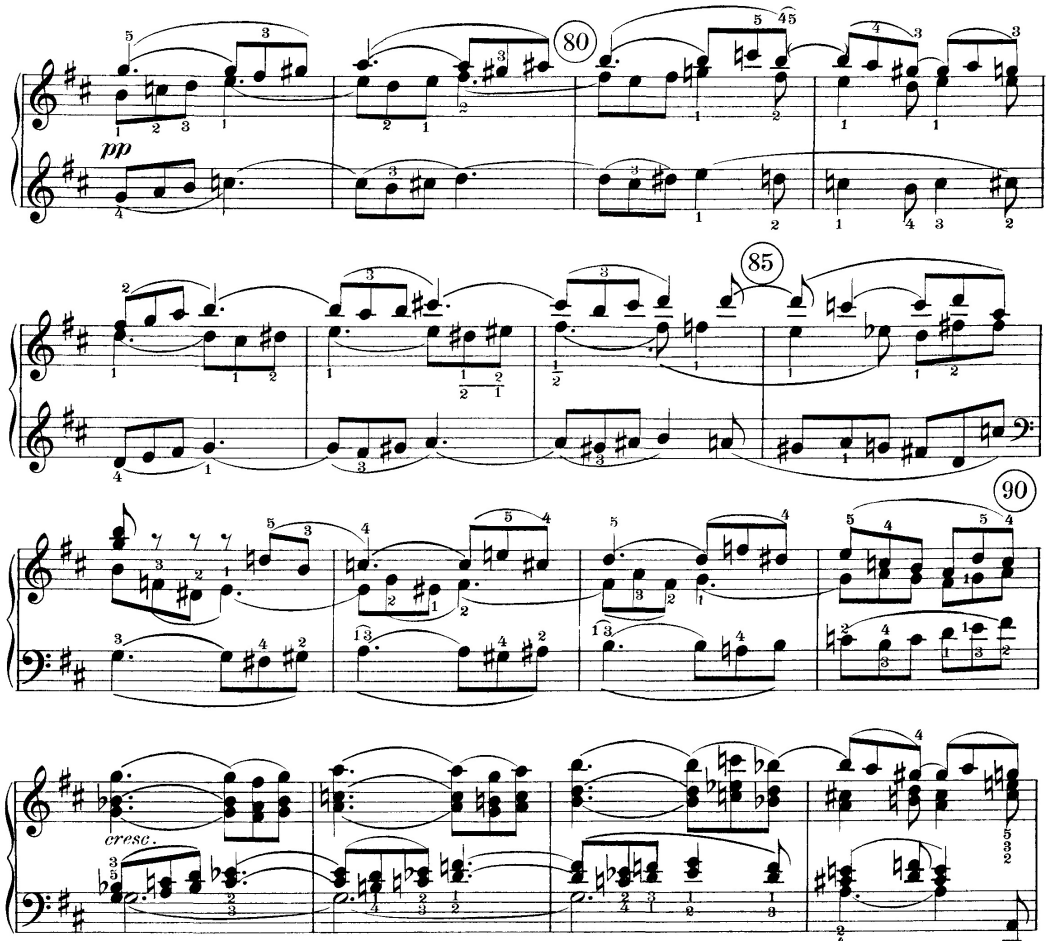


Figure 3: Beethoven, Piano Sonata No. 15 Op. 28/IV: *Allegro ma non troppo,* mm. 28-37.



[6] Rosen, Charles. Beethoven's Piano Sonatas: A Short Companion. (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2002): 162.

Figure 4: Beethoven, Piano Sonata No. 15 Op. 28/IV: *Allegro ma non troppo,* mm.78-93.



This movement is the first coherent instance of the fugal techniques that become so common in Beethoven's late period sonatas, reaching its point of highest development in Op. 106 and Op. 111. This development section, according to Andras Schiff, is not only very "Bachian" but also foreshadows the late Beethoven sonatas and string quartets. The fugue is integrated into the sonata by way of the left hand's eighth-note/dotted quarter-note rhythmic motive that exists in the cadence theme. Following fugal exploration of the motive in G major, G minor, and D minor, the fugal subject, at measure 100, returns to its subordinate role as the cadence theme reappears in the home dominant in preparation for the second return of the main theme.

Following the second return of the main theme, another transition, and a tonic recapitulation of the first episode, Beethoven caps off this seemingly simple rondo with a devilishly virtuosic coda that reaches its potent climax with a "brilliant new running counterpoint" in a *Più Allegro quasi presto* for the final seventeen bars of the sonata. (Figure 5)

Beethoven maintains the pastoral drone of the main theme throughout the coda with octave Ds and As underneath the rapid fire of virtuosic counterpoint. Beethoven reportedly made this final coda very difficult to play in order to "annoy the amateurs."[7]

Regarding the coda, Rosen writes: "The recapitulation is straightforward, uneventful, but the coda is extremely original. The minimal use of the subdominant until now in this movement receives its compensation. The initial left-hand drone starts pianissimo in the subdominant G major, uninterrupted this time by any melodic motif, and continues on its own, punctuated only by offbeat harmonies in the right hand. After 8 bars with a crescendo at the end, a *subito piano* initiates a pedal point on the dominant which lasts for ten bars with a crescendo; a dominant seventh harmony continues for another six bars descending from *ff* to *pp.* After a pause, a *Più Allegro quasi presto* introduces some brilliant counterpoint in the right hand over the initial bagpipe drone played in octaves, a challenge to an amateur pianist. The movement closes with eighteen bars of virtuosity."[8]
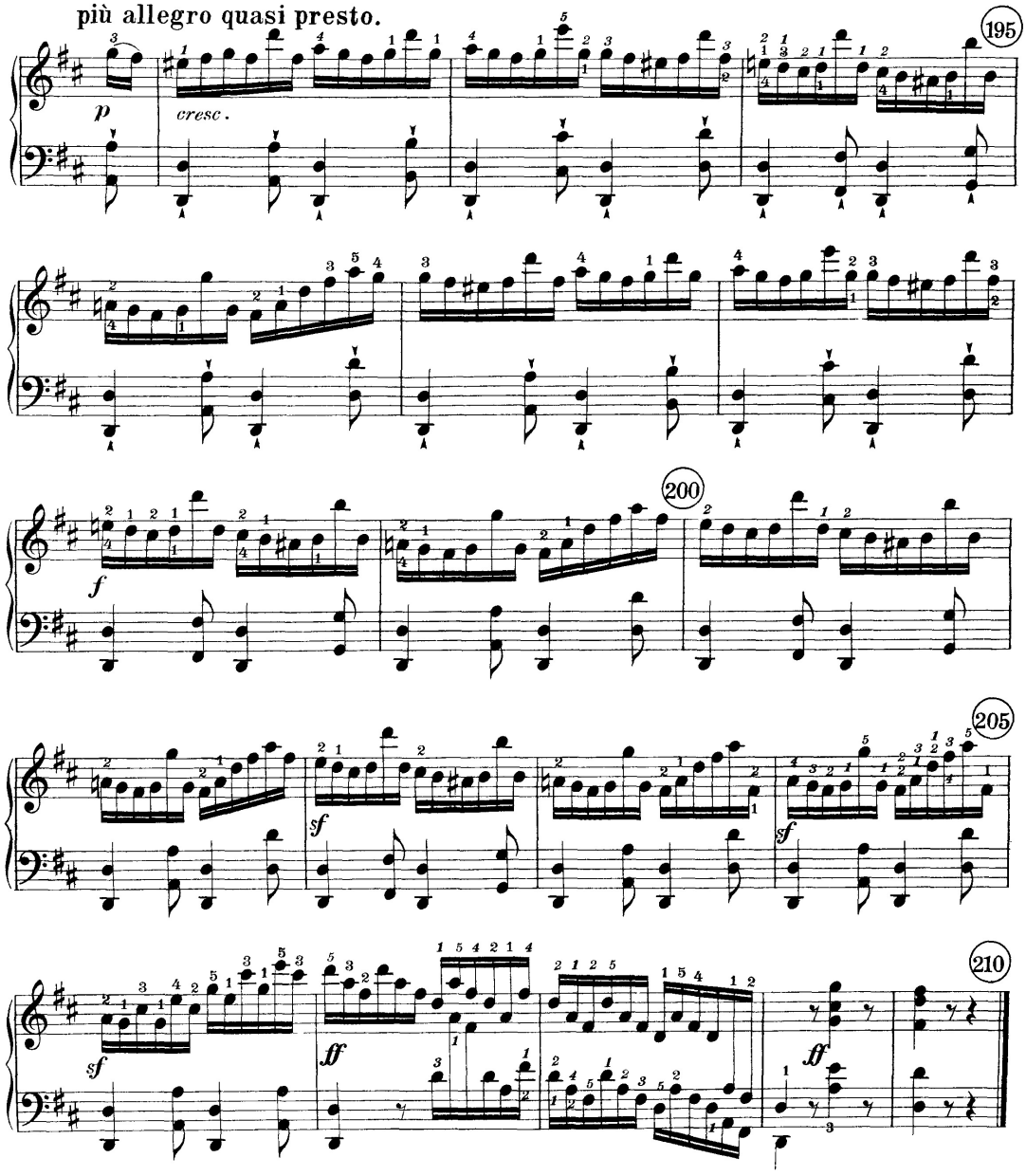
Figure 5: Beethoven, Piano Sonata No. 15 Op. 28/IV: *Allegro ma non troppo,* mm.192-210.

Op. 28 is strong substantiation for Beethoven's avant-gardism; evidenced by his use of irregular, unpredictable phrase structure in the opening movements that adds momentum and

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[7] Tovey: 121.

[8] Rosen: 162-63.



surprise to the listener's experience, the adaptations of folk songs and dances that exist in both Op. 28 and Op. 79 that would be a significant musical movement in future decades, and fugal techniques that point to his later works. We move now to another unlikely indicator of Beethoven's avant-gardism with Piano Sonata No. 25 in G major, Op. 79.

Op. 79, composed by Beethoven in 1809, comprises three short movements: *Presto alla tedesca, Andante,* and *Vivace;* a sonata form movement, an ABA barcarolle with coda, and, again, a final rondo. Op. 79 is one of Beethoven's shorter sonatas at only eleven minutes if all repeats are observed. It is also the shortest Beethoven sonata that contains more than two movements. All three short movements are in G: the lively first and last are in G major, the songful middle one in G minor. "It is not certain that Beethoven ever called this work a Sonatina; but the title is appropriate at all events to the slow movement and finale, which are not only on a small scale, but easy enough for young players. The first movement is decidedly more difficult—as difficult as some much bigger themes."[9] The sonata has a pronounced avoidance of "bravura showiness, unwarranted rhetoric, and above all, extravagant emotionalism."[10]

The sonata has been given the nickname "Cuckoo" because of the pattern of falling intervals and note groupings that appear and reappear throughout the first movement of the sonata. Specifically at measure 59, the left hand consistently leaps down the minor third from the second to third beat of each measure, creating a registral syncopation on beat two. (Figure 6) This also prepares the listener for the recap in its journey away from, and back to home dominant. "The *dolce* in bar 67 proves that the harmonic changes of the cuckoo calls do not coincide with the four-bar phrases, in spite of the *p* sign of the bar before."[11]

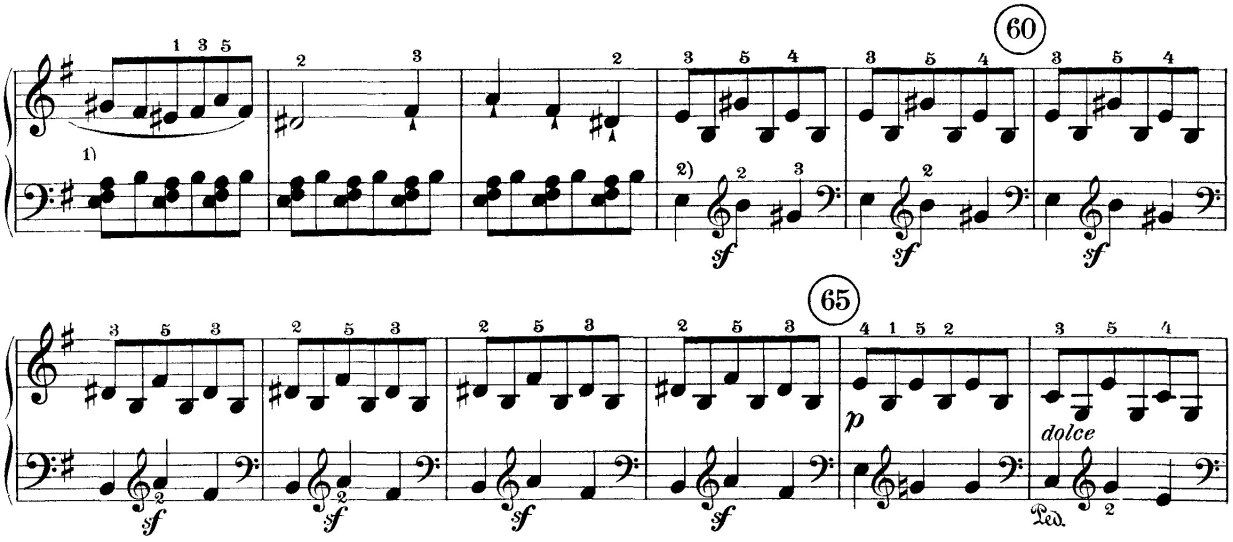
Figure 6: Beethoven, Piano Sonata No. 25 Op. 79/I: *Presto alla tecesca,* mm.59-66.

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[9] Tovey: 191.

[10] Tovey 193.

[11] Fischer, Edwin. Beethoven's Pianoforte Sonatas; A Guide for Students and Amateurs. (London: Faber and Faber, 1959): 90.



Concerning the first movement of Op. 79, Taub explicates: "So crisp and vibrant is the beginning of Sonata Op. 79 that a good performance will lift the spirits of everyone in the audience, carrying them along on soaring lines that—although they may sometimes seem to double back on themselves—always move listeners forward with unflagging energy… This sonata is one of the three (including also Op. 78 and Op. 81a) that comprise the fourth of the five periods of Beethoven's piano sonatas."[12] Op. 79 is the only Beethoven sonata in which clearly defined folk elements play a role. The tempo marking of *Presto alla tedesca* alludes to "an early form of the waltz, a development of the *Ländler.* In the late eighteenth century, the form was called an Allemande or a Teutscher (translated to Beethoven's *alla tedesca,* or 'German dance')."[13] Although Op. 79 was a small-scale work which was probably composed to sell to amateur pianists and make money, Beethoven's sophisticated, artistic mind continues to astonish. Though the composition is brimming with "square" eight-bar antecedent-consequent phrases, Beethoven demonstrates his prowess as an avant-gardist that will always continue to push

[12] Taub: 217.

[13] Rosen: 201.

boundaries, even in the simplest of compositions. He cannot help himself. Upon closer examination of the opening phrase of the *Presto alla tedesca,* we discover that the phrase only comprises seven bars. In the eighth bar, Beethoven once again pushes the momentum. Taub elucidates: "Not surprisingly, Beethoven's treatment of *tedesca* elements is highly sophisticated. The *forte* indication at the beginning of m. 8 is both unexpected and important to the drama, for it pushes forward the momentum of the phrase at a point where one would ordinarily expect the tonic cadence to conclude the phrase. (Figure 7) The extension of the first phrase leads to a cadence on D—the dominant—that leaves us suspended. Metrical stability also dissolves as the arpeggios that follow negate feelings of three beats per bar… Reestablishment of metrical stability in m. 24 provides a sense of relief, along with the cadence on A major (dominant of the dominant) as the left hand has the main line… At the end of [the] second theme area, there is another surprise *forte* at a cadence; we are once again propelled past the point that would ordinarily be the end of the phrase (m. 46)."[14]

Rosen states that the first movement of Op. 79 is a "Haydnesque work (several of the Haydn piano sonatas and piano trios have German dances for a finale), and the form of the exposition is decidedly derived from Haydn: short tonic section (bars 1-12), move to V with long development (12-46); short closing (46-47)."[15] Tovey, however, in the introduction to his analysis of Op. 79, strongly disagrees with Rosen's comparison of this sonata to Haydn: "To see in Op. 79 "a reversion to the style of an earlier generation" is to misconvenience earlier styles and its own style. You might as well say the same as of the drawings in Edward Lear's *Book of*

[14] Taub: 217.

[15] Rosen: 201.

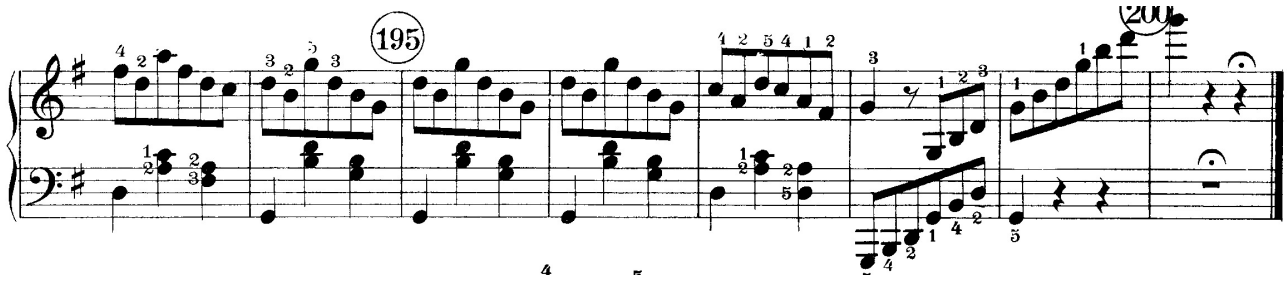
Nonsense. They show an obvious *aversion* to the style of the very latest generation as long as Time shall run! Slight and careless as Op. 79 is, its idioms are utterly unlike either Mozart's or Haydn's. The only thing they resemble is the style of Beethoven's third period, not ready to dawn for some years yet."[16]

The end of the movement—the last three measures—is unique. (Figure 8) No other Beethoven sonata endings are similar—with no repeated chords at the end and no *forte* pronouncement of the tonic.[17]

Figure 7: Beethoven, Piano Sonata No. 25 Op. 79/I: *Presto alla tecesca,* mm.1-12.
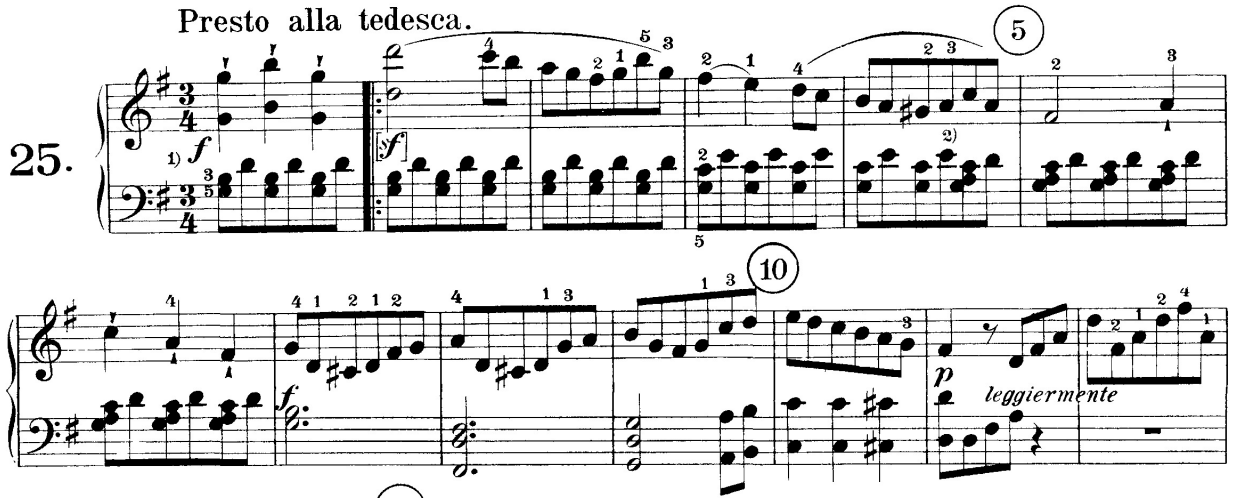


Figure 8: Beethoven, Piano Sonata No. 25 Op. 79/I: *Presto alla tecesca,* mm. 198-200.

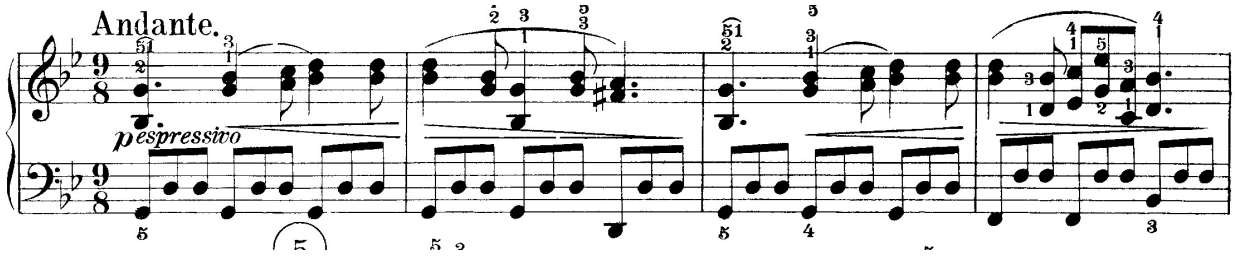


[16] Tovey: 191.

[17] Taub: 217.

The *Andante* in G minor is a barcarolle, and is unusual for Beethoven. The simple melody and the gentle bass, along with an atypical 9/8 meter, creates the feeling of the usual 6/8 gondoliera, but with added momentum and tension. Also, Beethoven's dynamic markings do not consistently line up with the strong beats in the left hand's rowing motive. He adds crescendo across bar-lines in order additionally increase momentum. (Figure 9) Rosen writes that this barcarolle is "presented like so many barcaroles by Rossini (and one by Chopin) as a duet for two sopranos. The central section in E flat major is a solo. The style of Italian opera is very much in evidence."[18]

Figure 9: Beethoven, Piano Sonata No. 25 Op. 79/II: *Andante,* mm. 1-4.



The final *Vivace* is a rondo, in "a style reminiscent of Beethoven's earliest work, but with more sophisticated transitions."[19] Back in G major, there is a "feeling of openness."[20] Beethoven, like most composers, would reuse material. In Op.79 we find multiple similarities to later works that indicate Op. 79 may have been used as a reference sketch for other works years later. For example, Op. 79 contains exact same chord progression that will be used eleven years later in the

[18] Rosen: 202.

[19] Rosen: 202.

[20] Taub: 217.

opening of a much more celebrated Sonata No. 30 in E major Op. 109. (Figures 10a and 10b) Another example is found in the *Alla danza tedesca* of the String Quartet in B-flat major, Op. 130, which is built upon an inversion of the first theme of the *Presto alla tedesca* of Op. 79. (Figures 11a and 11b) The Op. 130 string quartet was composed in 1825; sixteen years after Sonata No. 25.

Figure 10a: Beethoven, Piano Sonata No. 25 Op. 79/III: *Vivace,* mm. 1-8.

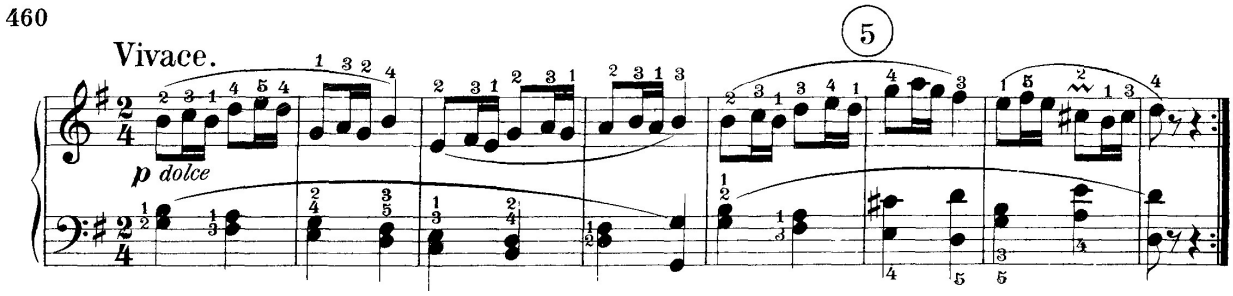


Figure 10b: Beethoven, Piano Sonata No. 30 Op. 109/I: *Vivace, ma non troppo,* mm. 1-9.
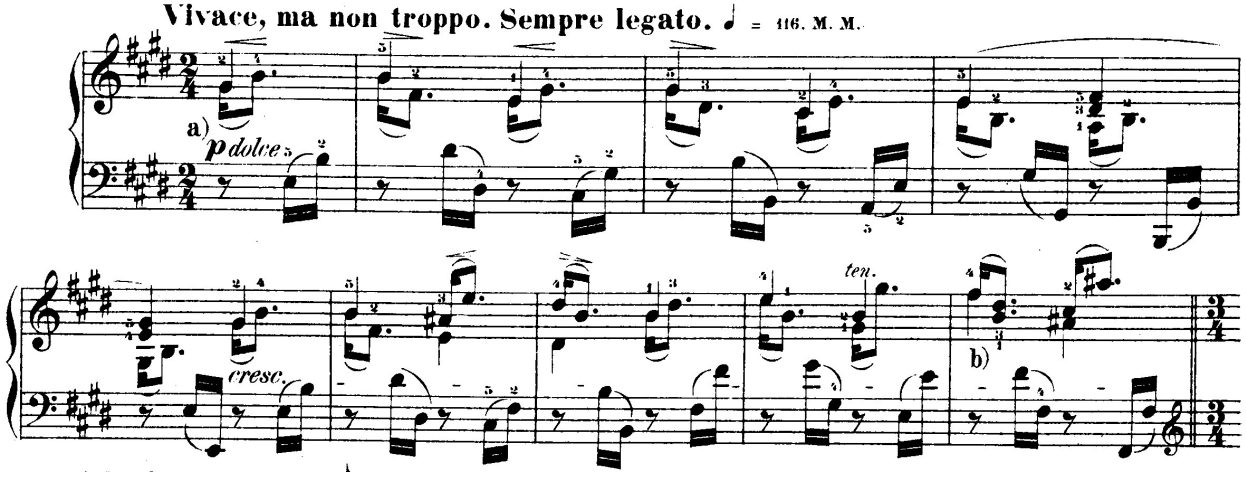


Figure 11a: Beethoven, Piano Sonata No. 25 Op. 79/I: *Presto alla tedesca,* mm. 1-6.

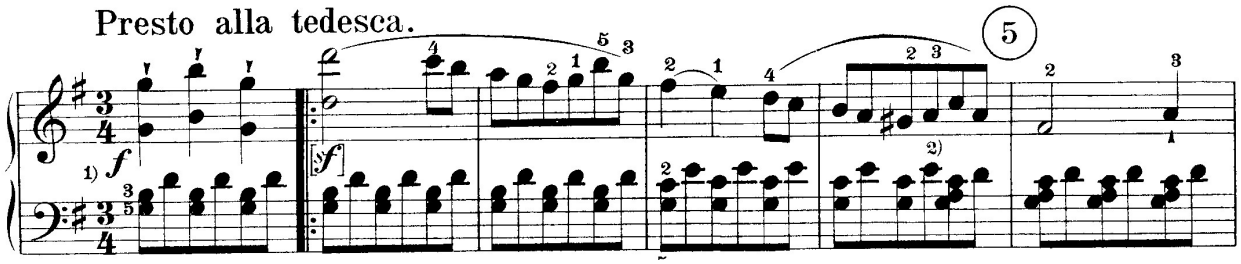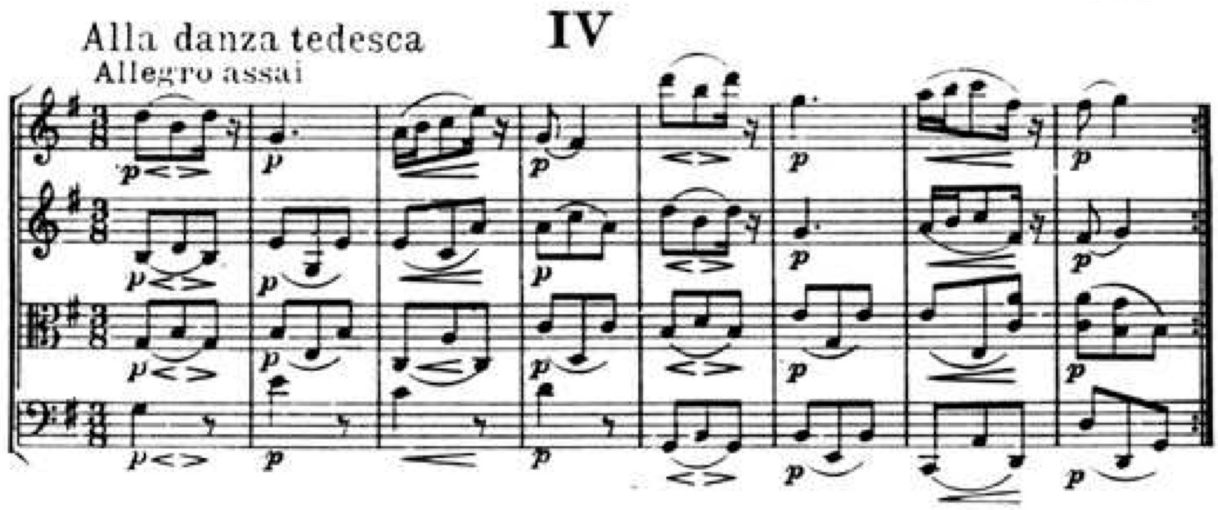


Figure 11b: Beethoven, String Quartet No. 13 in B-flat major, Op. 130/IV: *Alla danza tedesca,* mm. 1-6.



In terms of comparison and contrast, both Op. 28 and Op. 79, while neither are the typical examples that arise when the topic of Beethoven's avant-gardism is introduced, both include examples of Beethoven's resistance to prevailing musical forms and styles. Throughout all the examples introduced, one word continues to emerge as the composer's discernible musical goal: momentum. A thesaurus entry of the word consummately summarizes Beethoven's musical design and style: impetus, energy, force, power, strength, thrust. For Beethoven, compositional techniques that increased momentum also increased interest of the listener and the

unpredictability of his variable phrase structure. Op. 79, in particular, is compelling because of the initial pretense of squareness and strictness to four and eight-bar antecedent/consequent classical phrase construction. Immersive examination brings to light the dove-tailing, power driven, would-be cadences that thwart expectation with shortened phrases and sudden dynamic shifts that create a remarkable forward impetus.

Not only is Op. 79 more avant-garde than Op. 28 in its musical duplicity, it was more impactful to future composers. Felix Mendelssohn espoused the aesthetic of Beethoven's only Barcarolle as found in Op. 79 as a model for many of his *Songs without Words.* Schubert would adapt the melancholy air of the same movement in his setting of Goethe's Schäfers Klagelied. Beethoven would often leave the listener feeling uneasy through his rhythmically and tonally amorphous development sections and transitions. Several such examples occur in Op. 79, such as in the *Presto alla tedesca* wherein "metric stability dissolves as the arpeggios… negate feelings of three beats per bar."[21]

Ludwig van Beethoven was an avant-garde composer not because he yearned to be. The compositional devices employed by the composer seem to be born of instinct and necessity. It was his goal to breathe life into his music, and he did so because he instinctually could do nothing else. Though seldom studied, Op. 79 and Op. 28 accommodate an abundance of insight and comprehension of Beethoven's avant-gardism and compositional objectives.

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[21] Taub: 217.

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A translation of Fischer's original text byStanley Godman in collaboration with Paul Hamburger. A compilation of notes used for a course in 1945 which contains four lectures on "some general theme" followed by the artistic content of each of Beethoven's piano sonatas. Fischer admits in the introduction: "These informal talks make no claim to scholarly completeness or significance.

Frohlich, Martha. 1998. "Ideas of Closure, Derivation and Rhythm in the Sketches for the Andante of Beethoven's "Pastorale" Sonata Op. 28". *The Journal of Musicology.* 16, no. 3: 344-357.

A study of comparison between the source sketches and the final draft of the second movement of Beethoven's "Pastorale" Piano Sonata Op. 28. An extensive discussion of the multiple themes present from the beginning of the movement through the coda.

Rosen, Charles. *Beethoven's Piano Sonatas: A Short Companion*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 2002.

Charles Rosen places the works in context and provides an understanding of the formal principles involved in interpreting and performing this unique repertoire. In the second part of his book, he looks at the sonatas individually, from the earliest works of the 1770s through the sonatas of Beethoven's youthful popularity of the early 1800s, the subsequent years of mastery, the years of stress (1812-1817), and the last three sonatas of the 1820s.

Schiff, Andras. *Schiff on Beethoven.* http://www.theguardian.com/music/classical/page/0,,1943867,00.html

An eight-part series of audio recorded lecture-recitals on the Beethoven piano sonatas as presented by pianist András Schiff prior to performances from 2004-6 at Wigmore Hall in London.

Taub, Robert. *Playing the Beethoven Piano Sonatas*. Portland, Or: Amadeus Press, 2002.

The first half of the book comprises essays of preparation of musical elements such as improvisation, tempo, trills, etc. The second half of the book comprises non concert programs that encompass all 32 sonatas. Each sonata is discussed in terms of artistic and technical interpretation.

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